

In This Together: Glossary of Terms

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Accompaniment: The act of walking with others in their unique journeys with empathy, dignity, and presence. Rooted in the “art of accompaniment” taught by Pope Francis, it reflects the Church’s call to honor each person’s experience, support their growth, and foster belonging through compassionate relationship and mutual respect.

Belonging – A feeling of being accepted, included, and valued by a group or community. In Catholic tradition, belonging reflects our call to communion and unity with others.

Catholic Social Teaching – A body of doctrine developed by the Catholic Church on matters of social justice, human dignity, and the common good in society.

Common Good – The benefit or interests of all people in society. Catholic social teaching emphasizes working for the good of all, especially the marginalized.

Culture of Encounter – A Catholic call to move beyond superficial exchanges and genuinely engage with others through listening, empathy, and relationship. As Pope Francis says, this involves “listening to one another, sharing different views, coming to know each other and understanding one another.” Dialogue becomes a sacred space of bridge-building and love in a divided world.

Dialogue – Respectful and open communication that promotes understanding across differences. Rooted in the belief that every person has inherent dignity.

Dignity – The belief that every person has inherent worth because they are made in the image of God. A central theme in Catholic teaching.

Inclusion – The intentional act of creating spaces where all individuals feel welcomed, respected, and supported.

Justice – Promoting fairness, equity, and respect for all, especially those who are disadvantaged or marginalized. In the Catholic context, justice includes both charity and structural change.

Leadership as Service – A model of leadership focused on serving others, uplifting voices, and advancing the mission of justice and dignity.

Principles of Good Practice – Guidelines created to align student affairs work at Catholic colleges and universities with Catholic values, emphasizing inclusion, dignity, and dialogue.

Solidarity – Standing with others in mutual respect and support, especially with marginalized or oppressed communities. Catholic teaching encourages acting as one human family.

Values-Based Leadership – Leadership guided by a clear set of moral and ethical values, such as compassion, respect, and responsibility.